

Iran's Foreign Minister Says Iran Is Willing to Allow Japanese Vessels to Pass Through the Strait of Hormuz — How Should We View This Statement? What Considerations Lie Behind It?

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War is the continuation of politics; it is an activity within the sphere of the superstructure, and the limits of such activity are ultimately determined by the economic base. The war between the US/Israel and Iran has already greatly disrupted the global industrial chains, shaking the very foundation of global capitalist industrial production (on transnational capitalist production, see my article: The Rise and Fall of the Capitalist World-System (II): The Internal Structure of Transnational Production Capitalism). The global bourgeoisie will inevitably demand that the governments of the non-belligerent countries contain the war's impact, push for the war's end, and ensure production continues normally.

As we predicted earlier, this war cannot end within a week; it will become a war of attrition (see: Iran says the missiles it has launched so far are merely clearing out inventory, having caused 200 American casualties; it is about to deploy a series of "mysterious weapons" — what might they be?). The war has now lasted nearly a month; the Iranian regime has not collapsed, yet the global economy has already fallen into a panic — a panic on every front.

The interruption of oil and gas supply affects not only transport and the like, but has a huge impact on other industries:

Data show that Japanese companies supply more than 90% of the world's ArF photoresist and nearly 100% of EUV photoresist — core materials indispensable for manufacturing advanced chips of 7nm and below. More than 95% of Japan's crude oil and naphtha depends on imports from the Middle East, of which 70%–80% must pass through the Strait of Hormuz. Naphtha reserves suffice for only 20–30 days, and the buffer stock of the high-purity raw materials needed for photoresist production is even more limited. Once this maritime lifeline of energy is cut, Japan's photoresist industry will face the plight of "cooking without rice"... A medium-term blockade (3–6 months) will trigger even more serious consequences — large-scale production cuts and shutdowns of advanced ArF/EUV lines, and a sharp contraction of global supply of high-end photoresist. Japanese companies' revenue will be severely hit, forcing layoffs and business contraction^[1]. The Middle East is not only an energy export centre, but also a major global production base of petrochemical raw materials. Blockage of the strait controlling access to the Persian Gulf will directly affect the market supply of a variety of basic

chemicals. According to Morgan Stanley's latest force-majeure tracking report of 13 March, since the outbreak of the conflict, force-majeure declarations for the world's major chemical products have shown a chain reaction spreading across regions and categories. The olefin chain has become the worst-hit area of this round of shock. As of 12 March, 3.9% of global ethylene capacity was under force majeure, and 3.2% of propylene. By region, the hardest hit are Southeast Asia and Central Europe: affected ethylene capacity in Southeast Asia is as high as 20.4%, and in Central Europe an astonishing 60.2%^[2].

Beyond oil and gas, interruptions in the supply of other industrial products have also brought major effects.

For example, Qatar's helium:

Helium may seem niche, but it is a strategic gas spanning high-end research, industrial manufacturing, medical care, and aerospace. Consumption data for February 2026 confirm its core value: analysis, engineering, laboratory research, and specialty gases account for 22% — the largest end-use; controlled environments, optical fibre and semiconductors, and lifting gases tie for second at 17% each; MRI medical uses 15%; aerospace 9%; welding 8%; diving and leak detection 5% each; other uses 2%. Although after the 2022 Russia-Ukraine conflict, South Korea and other countries pushed hard for diversification of helium and neon supply and domestic mass production, three years later dependence on Qatari helium remains as high as 64% — diversification has achieved little. This situation confirms that the restructuring of the semiconductor supply chain is no short-term matter: long-term contract binding, technical barriers, and capacity monopolies make it hard for downstream enterprises to switch sources quickly. To date, Qatar's helium facilities show no sign of restarting; the Middle East conflict keeps escalating, and the 14-day supply-cut warning line is approaching. Whether the global chip industry can survive this ordeal depends not only on the geopolitical situation, but on whether the industrial chain can quickly fill this "tiny but fatal" short board^[3].

And overseas countries' polypropylene, polyethylene, and other chemical products:

Middle Eastern production facilities have also suffered direct hits. Kuwait's EQUATE declared its 1.15 million tonnes/year ethylene glycol under force majeure; Saudi Arabia's Sadara Chemical Company announced supply interruption of its ethanolamines and glycol ethers. Behind this supply crisis is the international market's heavy dependence on Middle Eastern chemicals. The Middle East holds about 35% of global polyethylene capacity and 28% of polypropylene capacity; the blockage of its exports has directly created a monthly supply gap of nearly 3 million tonnes of polyolefins in the international market. The expectation of supply interruption has been quickly reflected in prices. The North American spot market set the example first: ethylene spot prices rose 24.0% over the last week of February, North American propylene rose 12.8%, and North American polypropylene spot prices soared 25.0%^[4]. The crazy rise in upstream raw material prices is relentlessly crushing every far end of the industrial chain. GF Securities' 16 March building-materials industry report noted that, affected by

the US-Iran conflict, prices of key raw materials for building materials have soared compared with the start of the year: acrylic acid +134.8%, polyethylene +29.2%, PVC +26.4%.

There is also the aluminium supply of Qatar, Bahrain, and the UAE:

If oil is the blood of industry, aluminium is its bones. The Middle East is a key link in the global aluminium chain: in 2025, the region's total electrolytic aluminium capacity was 6.92 million tonnes, with actual output of 6.85 million tonnes — 9% of global supply. The region's aluminium industry is quite sensitive to the safety of shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, facing a two-way threat to its raw material imports and finished product exports. On 3 March, Qatar's aluminium smelter halted production after its facilities were attacked, its 648,000-tonne annual capacity accounting for 0.82% of the world; the next day, Alba of Bahrain declared force majeure and halted production, its 1.6 million-tonne annual capacity accounting for 2% of the world. By now, about 30% of the Middle East's electrolytic aluminium capacity has been materially affected^[5].

And the methanol of Iran and Saudi Arabia:

According to ICIS supply-demand data, methanol is Iran's largest chemical export, with exports of over 9 million tonnes in 2025; Saudi Arabia's methanol exports are also close to 4 million tonnes. ICIS data show that in 2025, Iran's methanol was exported mainly to China, with a small amount to India; Saudi supply went to China, India, the EU, and other regions. Methanol is mainly used to produce formaldehyde, MTBE, and acetic acid, with smaller amounts for DMT, MMA, methyl chloride, methylamine, ethylene glycol monomethyl ether, and fuel uses such as DME, biodiesel, and direct gasoline blending. The rise in methanol prices has also passed through to these products. In the coming weeks, the geopolitical situation will be the focus of the whole methanol chain, and demand for methanol derivatives in Q2 will be re-evaluated^[6].

And urea, sulphur, and other fertiliser-related products:

What many have not noticed is that this artery carries not only energy but also the "food of food" — fertiliser. About one-third of global fertiliser trade, and nearly half of sulphur exports, pass through here. War-torn Iran, the gatekeeper of this waterway, is itself a major global fertiliser producer. Iran and Qatar together account for about 20% of global urea trade volume. Iran, for instance, sits on the world's second-largest natural gas reserves. Natural gas is the main feedstock for producing urea (nitrogen fertiliser), and the sulphur obtained by desulphurising natural gas is key to producing phosphate fertilisers. With this unique advantage, Iran has long been one of the world's top three urea and sulphur exporters. Look at urea: India has a considerable rigid domestic supply gap that depends on imports — it is the world's largest urea importer; look at phosphate fertilisers: about half depend on imports; look at potash: having no domestic potash capacity, India depends almost entirely on imports. About 70% of India's urea imports come from countries around the Strait of Hormuz. Block this passage, and India's "grain" is cut off directly^[7].

The capacity of these chemical products cannot be expanded on demand — for example, a urea plant takes 2–3 years or even longer from groundbreaking to production^{[8][9]}.

Globalised production has today completed the process of quantitative change leading to qualitative change. For instance, many countries import chemicals directly from the Middle East rather than processing them at home, so once war breaks out, for most countries it is not at all as simple as switching oil and gas suppliers to another country. The enormous impact of this war reflects how far our world has travelled along the road of globalisation. In a sense, the whole world has already formed a civil society based on the material metabolic process of global industrial production — only the state standing opposed to civil society has not yet taken shape; what we face is a world of contending warlords.

Apart from the Iranian regime, which faces a threat of life and death, and the Israeli regime, which wants Iran dead, all other countries hope to restore transport as soon as possible, secure enterprise supplies, and avoid forced shutdowns. Hence, in the Security Council vote on the resolution, China and Russia abstained.

On the afternoon of 11 March local time (the early morning of 12 March Beijing time), the UN Security Council adopted, by 13 votes in favour and 2 abstentions, a draft resolution submitted by Bahrain on behalf of the Gulf Cooperation Council member states and Jordan, supported by 135 UN member states, becoming Security Council Resolution 2817. Russia and China abstained. The resolution condemns Iran's strikes against several Gulf states, holding these acts to violate international law and constitute a threat to international peace and security; it expresses regret at attacks on civilian targets and the civilian casualties; it demands that Iran immediately stop its attacks on these countries and fully fulfil its obligations under international law; it also condemns any Iranian act or threat to close or obstruct international shipping in the Strait of Hormuz^[10].

What does an abstention mean? It means the objective of the matter is unobjectionable, but there is partiality — so one neither supports nor opposes. A similar situation occurred with the resolution on the Houthis in January:

On that day, the UN Security Council adopted Resolution 2812 by 13 votes in favour, 0 against, and 2 abstentions; China and Russia abstained. The Russian representative said: "We cannot support this document. The Security Council's technical extension of the relevant mechanism this time has brought no new value." She stressed that at the request of regional partners, Russia would not block the resolution, but on the basis of the actual situation, the Security Council should focus its attention on monitoring vessels in the Caribbean waters rather than the Red Sea. Ambassador Sun Lei, China's Deputy Permanent Representative, said in his explanatory statement after the vote on extending the mandate for reporting on ship attacks in the Red Sea that China's voting position reflected the continuity of China's position. The Red Sea, he said, is an important international trade route;

safeguarding the security of the shipping lanes there is the common responsibility of all parties. All parties should respect the navigation rights of commercial vessels in the Red Sea under international law, oppose attacks on and seizure of civilian vessels, and jointly maintain the international trade order^[11].

This time the six countries (now seven, since South Korea has joined^{[12][13]})...

Trump's war gang has also felt the pressure. "The International Energy Agency (IEA) has officially defined the current global energy crisis as the largest supply disruption in the history of the oil market"^[14].

On the one hand, Trump wants to send amphibious assault ships to seize islands; on the other, he claims to be "considering a gradual de-escalation of military operations against Iran"^{[15][16]}.

On the Iranian side, it also realises that this practice of holding the global economy hostage and overturning the table cannot be sustained, so it has proposed that "China can serve as a mediator between the United States and Iran"^{[17][18]}.

In a world of globalised production, the position of the "warlords" is in fact more solid. One does not even need nuclear weapons like North Korea: with missiles, drone production capacity, and a certain strategic depth, one can control a vast area within the radius of one's missiles. Iran's successful experience will inevitably inspire a group of middle powers — Turkey, Brazil, Indonesia — to develop independent ballistic missiles and satellite positioning systems as soon as possible.

Because the development of the capitalist world is uneven, there will always be countries torn by internal contradictions that need to shift contradictions abroad through war. This makes war an inevitable phenomenon. In a unipolar world, such wars have limited impact on the global economy, because the single pole can control the direction of the war. But after America's decline, the unipolar world cannot be restored. Even if China replaces America as the largest pole, it cannot replicate America's "unipolar moment." Multipolarity will be a long-term basic structure (see: How Many Poles in a Multipolar World? A Look Ahead to 2050). Before the transnational proletariat steps onto the stage of history as a political force, the transnational bourgeoisie cannot solve the phenomenon of "contending warlords"; so this chaotic situation of constant military conflict will continue for many years, from time to time causing crises at the global level.

Notes

^[1] "Japan's photoresist supply chain on the brink of rupture; global semiconductors in danger" (WeChat article)

中文原文：日本光刻胶供应链濒临断裂，全球半导体告急

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/sSD67ElTdHsueo2ijJW3rQ>

[2] "Winds rise over the Persian Gulf: is a global supply-chain crisis coming?" (WeChat article)

中文原文：风起波斯湾，全球产供应链危机袭来？

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/gsnqL224EC1xeI7zC9u-UA>

[3] "In depth | Iran 'cuts off' the global chip helium supply chain" (WeChat article)

中文原文：深度 | 伊朗“炸断”全球芯片氦气供应链

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/YHXCavbuGDvvLzjdoUu5Aw>

[4] "Winds rise over the Persian Gulf: is a global supply-chain crisis coming?" (WeChat article)

中文原文：风起波斯湾，全球产供应链危机袭来？

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/gsnqL224EC1xeI7zC9u-UA>

[5] "Winds rise over the Persian Gulf: is a global supply-chain crisis coming?" (WeChat article)

中文原文：风起波斯湾，全球产供应链危机袭来？

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/gsnqL224EC1xeI7zC9u-UA>

[6] "20 million tonnes/year of methanol supply restricted; Q2 market shrouded in gloom" (WeChat article)

中文原文：2000万吨/年甲醇供应受限，二季度市场阴霾笼罩

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/pHpyVJoDwuoL9doaTV-nwQ>

[7] "The US-Israel war with Iran — what does it have to do with the world's food? || Changhong Wobo" (WeChat article)

中文原文：美以与伊朗打仗，关全球粮食什么事？|| 长虹卧波

https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/4XghHZt8qbqn617Gd_ekcw

[8] "Huaqiang Chemical starts construction of 400,000-tonne ammonia / 300,000-tonne urea plant": the project started that day has an annual capacity of 400,000 tonnes of synthetic ammonia and 300,000 tonnes of urea, an investment of 5.2 billion yuan — the largest project in the industrial park, with a construction period of 24 months. (WeChat article)

中文原文：《华强化工40万吨合成氨/30万吨尿素开工》当日启动建设的是年产40万吨合成氨30万吨尿素项目。该项目投资52亿元，是产业园投资规模最大的项目，建设周期24个月。

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/24z6Rrvu1dLzBAi6K2LrRA>

[9] "To be commissioned in 2030! Turkmenistan starts building a new plant" (WeChat article)

中文原文：2030年投产！土库曼斯坦新建新厂

https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/iJYlZOTpcApja8_bzCI6tg

[10] "The UN adopts Resolution 2817; Russia and China abstain" (Baidu Baijiahao)

中文原文：联合国通过第2817号决议，俄罗斯和中国投弃权票

<https://baijiahao.baidu.com/s?id=1859422001108766422&wfr=spider&for=pc>

[11] "China and Russia abstain" (Baidu Baijiahao)

中文原文：中俄投了弃权票

<https://baijiahao.baidu.com/s?id=1854336932505594872&wfr=spider&for=pc>

[12] "South Korea joins the seven-nation joint statement condemning Iran's blockade of the Strait of Hormuz": South Korea's foreign ministry said the decision took comprehensive account of the government's basic position on the

safety of international sea lanes and freedom of navigation, the direction of the international community, and the direct impact of obstruction in the Strait of Hormuz on Korea's energy supply and economy. (Eastmoney)

中文原文：《韩国加入七国联合声明 谴责伊朗封锁霍尔木兹海峡》韩国外交部表示，此决定综合考虑了韩国政府关于国际海上通道安全与航行自由的基本立场、国际社会动向，以及霍尔木兹海峡通航受阻对韩国能源供应和经济产生的直接影响。

<https://finance.eastmoney.com/a/202603203679267470.html>

[13] "Six nations issue a joint statement: ready to take action to safeguard the security of the Strait of Hormuz" (Baidu Baijiahao)

中文原文：六国发表联合声明：准备采取行动保障霍尔木兹海峡安全

<https://baijiahao.baidu.com/s?id=1860139856122527975&wfr=spider&for=pc>

[14] "IEA heavyweight warning! The largest oil supply disruption in history; global funds dump paper assets for physical goods": the International Energy Agency (IEA) has officially defined the current global energy crisis as the largest supply disruption in the history of the oil market. The shock has triggered a "monetary fracture," forcing global funds to accelerate their shift from paper assets to physical commodities. (WeChat article)

中文原文：《IEA 重磅警告！史上最大石油供应中断，全球资金狂抛纸面资产抢实物》国际能源署（IEA）正式将当前全球能源危机定义为石油市场有史以来最大规模的供应中断。这一冲击已引发“货币断裂”（monetary fracture），迫使全球资金从纸面资产加速转向实物商品。

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/CmCSdp1-fctvo3mimJLbrw>

[15] "Trump says he is considering a gradual de-escalation of military operations against Iran, and will no longer undertake the guard and patrol of the Strait of Hormuz when necessary; when the US wants to end the conflict, Israel will do the same" (WeChat article)

中文原文：特朗普称正考虑逐步降级对伊朗的军事行动，必要时将不再承担霍尔木兹海峡的守卫与巡航工作；当美国想结束冲突时，以色列也会同步

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/yC9oJ7UhYDcz6DG4FLlOYw>

[16] "'US and European missile stockpiles are almost exhausted!' German defence giant speaks out: if the war lasts another month, missile reserves will run out; Iranian drones are very cheap, while fighting them is very costly" (WeChat article)

中文原文：“美欧导弹库存几乎枯竭！”德国军工巨头发声：战争再持续一个月导弹储备就会耗尽，伊朗无人机成本很低，与其对抗成本却很高

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/hReIWOk2NzJ-vPDXs5Xo1g>

[17] "Iran's foreign minister: China can serve as a mediator between the US and Iran": In an interview with Al Jazeera, Araghchi said: "We will listen to any proposal that meets our demands and fits our conditions. But we are not seeking a ceasefire, because we do not want the flames of war to reignite after a while. We want the war to end completely and permanently. We do not believe in the ceasefire system; we believe only in the true end of the war." Araghchi further noted that China and some other countries can serve as mediators in resolving the Middle East conflict. He specifically mentioned China's successful and positive mediation between Iran and Saudi Arabia, and said he believed both sides still adhered to the agreement reached then. (Sina Finance)

中文原文：《伊朗外长：中国可以在美国和伊朗之间充当调停人》阿拉格齐在接受半岛电视台采访时表示：“我们将听取任何满足我方要求并符合我方条件的建议。但我方不寻求达成停火，因为我方不希望一段时间后战火再度燃起。我方希望，战争能够全面且永久结束。我们不相信停火制度，我们只相信战争真正的结束。”阿拉格齐进一步指出，中国和其他一些国家可以在解决中东冲突中充当调停人。他特别提到，中国在伊朗和沙特阿拉伯之间进行了成功且积极的斡旋，并相信双方依然遵守着当时达成的协议。

<https://finance.sina.com.cn/wm/2026-03-19/doc-inhrpfmt8652105.shtml>

[18] "Iran's president: no intention to clash with Islamic countries — 'they are our brothers'": In a video message on the occasion of the Iranian New Year (Nowruz), Pezeshkian said: "We have no intention of any difference with Islamic countries. We do not seek conflict or war with Islamic countries. They are our brothers." He noted that the United States and Israel caused the tension between Iran and the region's Islamic countries. Pezeshkian said Iran is ready to resolve all issues with its neighbours and proposed building a security mechanism among the Middle East's Islamic countries to guarantee regional peace, security, and stability. (Baidu Baijiahao)

中文原文：《伊朗总统：无意与伊斯兰国家发生冲突，“他们是我们的兄弟”》佩泽希齐扬当日在伊朗新年诺鲁孜节到来之际发表视频致辞。他说：“我们无意与伊斯兰国家产生任何分歧。我们不寻求与伊斯兰国家发生冲突或战争。他们是我们的兄弟。”他指出，美国和以色列造成了伊朗同地区伊斯兰国家之间的紧张局势。佩泽希齐扬表示，伊朗已准备好解决与邻国的所有问题，并提出组建中东伊斯兰国家之间的安全机制，以保障地区和平、安全与稳定。

<https://baijiahao.baidu.com/s?id=1860243651566691908&wfr=spider&for=pc>

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